

COMPUTING COMFORT

You know you want one, but an informed decision you can make not. We can change that. In test... 32 of the best!

Michael Browne

The words portability, connectivity, and convenience describe the need for laptops best. It's important to be connected at all times these days: knowledge received late is knowledge lost in many cases. Then there are those emergencies when you just have to jot down a few notes, and a paper and pen aren't within reach...

There are also those for whom a laptop is not a necessity but part of their lifestyle—a classy extension of oneself, a wardrobe accessory, or even a status symbol.

Anyone who has ever attended a LAN party will testify to the pain in the neck, shoulders, and other regions that result from lugging a bulky cabinet, LCD, or worse still—a CRT, and peripherals about. Now think convenience. Although a laptop is still not a Desktop replacement for gamers, a good mouse coupled with a reasonably-configured laptop will see you through most fragging sessions just as easily.

Inbuilt goodies like memory card readers, wireless connectivity, and Bluetooth are something 99 per cent of Desktops won't have. Although a fast Desktop would still leave the best-performing laptops grovelling in the dirt, the point here is that notebooks *are* a solution for various needs—and manufacturers are tailoring them to suit those.

A word about the reviews that follow: Acer, Dell, and Fujitsu are going through a product refresh cycle. The older models are no longer available, and the new range wasn't out at the time of this writing. Expect reviews of laptops from those manufacturers in our *Bazaar* section in the issues to come.

Value Laptops

This category is the most populous of the four. Compaq aside, we have mostly home-grown brands here. In fact, if you want a big-brand laptop and are restricted to the

45K price point, we suggest you dump the idea of a big brand altogether. While we haven't yet gotten to US prices, it's good to see Indian vendors taking such aggressive price points. Bear in mind that hardware scales with price, so a Rs 20K laptop will most certainly win no processing accolades.

ACI was present in force in this category with four models. Compaq and Intex featured a model each; LG and HCL featured three apiece. Zenith made it to the party with two laptops.

Features

The most attractive notebook here is the Compaq Presario v3225AU. The palm-rest and even the outer lid feature the same treatment HP uses on its high-end DV series. This material is extremely smooth to the touch, and it seems it will easily withstand the rigours of daily use. It's a real pity that HP chose to use the same material on the touchpad. This makes it too slippery—just not enough

